

THE EQUALISER

CHOOSING THE SAFE MIDDLE GROUND ISN'T ALWAYS A PRUDENT DECISION. BUT DONE RIGHT, IT CAN PAY OFF AS A WELL-THOUGHT-OUT INVESTMENT. THE NEW GENERATION OF THE GLC SEEMS TO DO JUST THAT

BY ABHIK DAS

This new, second generation of the GLC comes after an eight-month hiatus from Mercedes' India portfolio. The company had cited substantial demand from customers for the model in its absence. These potential customers for the GLC are now going to get a refreshed new look that's more rounded compared to the model it replaces. The design changes are apparent in the LED headlamps, the new grille, the redesigned rear tail lamps and the overall look, making it look softer yet more stately. The new 19-inch wheels enhance the aesthetics further, and that's a good thing as no AMG-line additions are currently on offer for the SUV.

The understated yet elegant exterior of the GLC is in contrast with the opulent feel of the interior. The wooden trim with the pin striping on the dashboard, the aluminium trims around the window controls, the solid clicks of the air-con vent controls, the general touch and feel of materials, and many other such tiny details come together to make this cabin exude a strong sense of quality. The increase in overall length of the car has led to extra boot storage of 70 litres apart from liberating more legroom at the rear. The 12.3-inch instrumentation is customisable and looks crisp while being well-complemented with the 11.9-inch infotainment that has a host of in-car functions divided into various menus. There is a dedicated off-road display in the infotainment feature, showing various parameters like gradient angle and roll angle. A new feature is the 'Transparent Bonnet' camera setting that shows the terrain under the front wheels.

Engine: 2-litre, in-line 4-cyl, turbo-petrol
Max Power: 258 bhp@5,800 rpm
Price Rs 73.5 lakh (ex-showroom)

To drive the new GLC is a distinct experience, especially with the more powerful four-cylinder turbo-petrol under the hood of the GLC 300 variant that we've driven for this review. The result is about 61 bhp increase in horsepower and 80 Nm increase in torque, which, for a passenger car, is ample. Not just that, the Integrated Starter Generator (ISG) provides an extra boost of up to 200 Nm for a few seconds, resulting in the car clocking an impressive acceleration of 6.2 seconds for a 0-100 kmph sprint. The GLC also displays a good amount of poise and stability around corners and even broken roads fail to shake off its composure even without air-suspension.

The new GLC doesn't do anything spectacularly different from other cars competing with it, thus remaining in that safe middle ground. Yet, whatever it does, it does with confidence and pride, imbibing all the qualities that make a product worthy of donning the three-pointed Mercedes star. In this new form, the GLC is larger and more stylish on the outside, luxurious on the inside with great features, offers a superb build quality, and boasts an uprated engine with satisfying levels of performance. There is almost nothing to fault at first impression. ■